

UNIT I - VOCABULARY

Communication Skills (English) — Course Code 311303

1.1 PHONETICS

Phonetics is the study of speech sounds — how they are produced, transmitted, and perceived. English has **44 phonemes** (distinct sounds), divided into three categories:

A. Vowels (12 Monophthongs)

Vowel sounds are produced without any obstruction to the airflow. English has 12 pure vowel sounds, divided into short and long vowels.

Short Vowels (7): | Symbol | Example Word | |----|-----| | /ɪ/ | sit |
| | /e/ | bed | | /æ/ | cat | | /ʌ/ | cup | | /ɒ/ | hot | | /ʊ/ | put | | /ə/ | about (schwa) |

Long Vowels (5): | Symbol | Example Word | |----|-----| | /i:/ | see | | /ɑ:/ | car | | /ɔ:/ | saw | | /u:/ | food | | /ɜ:/ | bird |

B. Consonants (24)

Consonants are produced with some obstruction of airflow, classified by **place of articulation** (where the sound is made) and **manner of articulation** (how it's made).

By Manner of Articulation: - **Plosives (Stops):** /p, b, t, d, k, g/ — complete blockage then release - **Fricatives:** /f, v, θ, ð, s, z, ʃ, ʒ, h/ — narrow gap causing friction - **Affricates:** /tʃ, dʒ/ — combination of plosive + fricative (e.g., “ch”urch, “j”udge) - **Nasals:** /m, n, ŋ/ — air released through the nose - **Lateral:** /l/ — air flows around the sides of the tongue - **Approximants/Glides:** /r, j, w/ — slight narrowing, vowel-like quality

Voiced vs Voiceless pairs (important for pronunciation): | Voiceless |
Voiced | |----|-----| | /p/ | pen | | /b/ | ben | | /t/ | tin | | /d/ | din | | /k/ | cap |
| /g/ | gap | | /f/ | fan | | /v/ | van | | /s/ | sip | | /z/ | zip |

C. Diphthongs (8)

A diphthong is a **glide from one vowel sound to another within the same syllable** — the tongue moves position while producing the sound.

Symbol	Example Word
/eɪ/	day
/aɪ/	my
/ɔɪ/	boy
/aʊ/	now
/əʊ/	go
/ɪə/	here

/eə/	hair
/ʊə/	tour

Practice tip (relevant to your lab work): When transcribing 20 words phonetically, break each word into its phonemes using slashes, e.g., *cat* → /kæt/, *phone* → /fəʊn/.

1.2 PREFIX & SUFFIX

Affixes are added to root/base words to change their meaning or grammatical function.

Prefix

A prefix is added **before** a root word to modify its meaning (usually doesn't change word class).

Prefix	Meaning	Example
un-	not	unhappy
re-	again	rewrite
dis-	opposite/not	disagree
mis-	wrongly	misunderstand
pre-	before	preview
post-	after	postpone
im-/in-	not	impossible, incomplete
sub-	under	submarine
inter-	between	international
anti-	against	antisocial
auto-	self	autobiography
bi-	two	bicycle
co-	together	cooperate
ex-	former/out	ex-president
non-	not	nonsense
over-	excessive	overeat
under-	insufficient	underpaid
super-	above	superhuman

Suffix

A suffix is added **after** a root word — it often **changes the word's grammatical category** (noun → adjective, verb → noun, etc.).

Noun-forming suffixes: -tion, -ment, -ness, -ity, -er/-or, -ship -
 educate → education; develop → develop**ment**; happy → happiness;
 friend → friend**ship**

Adjective-forming suffixes: -ful, -less, -able/-ible, -ous, -al, -ive -
 hope → hope**ful**; care → care**less**; comfort → comfort**able**; danger →
 danger**ous**

Verb-forming suffixes: -ize/-ise, -fy, -en - modern → modern**ize**;
 simple → simpl**ify**; short → short**en**

Adverb-forming suffix: -ly - quick → quick**ly**; happy → happ**ily**

Why it matters: Prefixes and suffixes give you the power to build multiple words from a single root, increasing precision and vocabulary flexibility (e.g., *act* → *react*, *enact*, *action*, *active*, *activate*, *inactive*).

1.3 SYNONYMS & ANTONYMS

Synonyms

Words with the **same or nearly the same meaning**. Used to avoid repetition and add variety/precision to writing.

Word	Synonyms
Happy	Joyful, Glad, Cheerful, Content
Big	Large, Huge, Enormous, Vast
Beautiful	Attractive, Pretty, Lovely, Gorgeous
Smart	Intelligent, Clever, Sharp, Bright
Fast	Quick, Rapid, Swift, Speedy

Note: True synonyms are rare — most words are near-synonyms with slightly different **shades of meaning, tone, or context** (e.g., “slim” is positive, “skinny” can be negative, though both mean “thin”).

Antonyms

Words with **opposite meanings**. Three types:

1. **Gradable antonyms** (a scale exists between them): hot ↔ cold, big ↔ small
2. **Complementary antonyms** (no middle ground): alive ↔ dead, true ↔ false
3. **Relational antonyms** (imply a relationship): teacher ↔ student, buy ↔ sell

Word	Antonym
Happy	Sad
Ancient	Modern
Increase	Decrease
Generous	Stingy
Victory	Defeat

Context & Usage: The same word can have different synonyms/antonyms depending on context. - “Fair” (*just*) → synonym: impartial; antonym: unjust - “Fair” (*skin tone*) → synonym: light; antonym: dark

1.4 HOMOPHONES

Homophones are words that **sound identical but differ in spelling and meaning**.

Homophone Pair	Meaning
there / their / they’re	place / possession / contraction of “they are” direction / also-

to / too / two	excessive / number
write / right	to inscribe / correct or direction
flower / flour	plant part / baking ingredient
sea / see	ocean / to view
hear / here	to perceive sound / this place
break / brake	to shatter / stopping device
son / sun	male child / star
meat / meet	food / to encounter
peace / piece	calm / a portion
where / wear	location / to put on clothing
knight / night	medieval soldier / evening

Why they matter: Homophones are a common source of spelling errors because pronunciation gives no clue to correct spelling — you must rely on **context and meaning**.

Tip: Always check the sentence context: “*I want to go THERE*” vs “*THEIR house is big*” vs “*THEY'RE coming today*.”

1.5 COLLOCATIONS

A collocation is a **natural pairing/combination of words** that native speakers habitually use together. Using the “wrong” combination sounds unnatural even if grammatically correct.

Types of Collocations

- Adjective + Noun**
 - *heavy rain* (not “strong rain”)
 - *strong coffee* (not “powerful coffee”)
- Verb + Noun**
 - *make a decision* (not “do a decision”)
 - *take a photo, do homework, give advice*
- Adverb + Adjective**
 - *deeply concerned, highly unlikely, fully aware*
- Verb + Preposition**
 - *rely on, insist on, apologize for, deal with*
- Noun + Noun**
 - *a pair of shoes, a bar of soap, a piece of advice*
- Verb + Adverb**
 - *speak fluently, whisper softly, argue loudly*

Common Examples Table

Collocation	Meaning/Usage
make a mistake	commit an error
catch a cold	fall sick
pay attention	focus/concentrate
take a break	rest for a while
keep a promise	fulfill a commitment

break a record	surpass a previous best
do business	conduct trade
save time	be efficient
lose weight	reduce body weight
set a goal	establish a target

Why collocations matter: They make your English sound natural and fluent rather than “translated” or robotic. Native-like fluency depends heavily on correct collocation use, especially in professional and technical writing.

Quick Revision Summary

Topic	Core Idea	Skill Developed
Phonetics	Sound system: 12 vowels, 24 consonants, 8 diphthongs	Correct pronunciation
Prefix & Suffix	Word-building through affixes	Vocabulary flexibility
Synonyms & Antonyms	Words with similar/opposite meaning	Precision & variety in expression
Homophones	Same sound, different spelling/meaning	Spelling accuracy
Collocations	Natural word partnerships	Fluency & naturalness

Aligned to CO1: “Construct grammatically correct sentences in English” and TLOs 1.1–1.5 as per MSBTE syllabus.